

Othello - Notes

Shakespeare, William. *The Tragedy of Othello, The Moore of Venice*. Toronto: Washington Square Press New Folger's Edition, 1993.

- The tragedy of *Othello* was written between 1602 and 1604.
- Its popularity was assured among Shakespeare's contemporaries because it revolves around Italian wickedness. Even the penny groundlings could associate the names Machiavelli and Borgia with Italy: Venice itself had a reputation for passionate beautiful women, quick-tempered, aggressive men and crimes of jealousy. As well, Moorish exploits were well-known in London: Moorish pirates were active in the Mediterranean area; Moors had participated in the siege of Malta by Turks in 1565; they were regarded as exotics who were fascinatingly intriguing. Capitalizing on Londoners' interests and the acting talents of Richard Burbage, a fine actor in Shakespeare's acting company, Shakespeare created yet another resounding success.
- The plot of *Othello* Shakespeare found in a collection of stories, *Hecatommithi* (1565) written by Giraldi Cinthio. Cinthio's tale involved jealousy and included Disdemona, an unnamed Moor, a Captain, an ensign and the ensign's wife. There the similarities end, for Shakespeare transmutes a sordid tale into a tragedy involving a noble Moor who is driven to murder his beloved, loving wife by an implacable villain who seemingly is an honest man.

The Structure of the Play

- Tragedies traditionally had 5 acts:
 - Act I - basically exposition but establishes what is to be the conflict of the play
 - Act II - the rising action intensifies
 - the forces opposed to the tragic protagonist further their schemes
 - Act III - the drama reaches its climax
 - Act IV - the falling action begins
 - complications in the antagonist's schemes begin to emerge
 - Act V - the tragic protagonist is destroyed; the antagonist also meets with defeat.
- To the classic five-act structure Shakespeare added elements in his plays that came to be recognized as his trademarks:

1) In defiance of Aristotle's dictum that tragedies should contain no humor, Shakespeare made dramatic use of humor in his tragedies. The clown in *Othello* makes a small contribution to the action of the play; his main purpose is to diffuse the tension created in highly suspenseful scenes. Shakespeare's audiences had no between-act breaks; they viewed the action from start to finish. The penny groundlings reacted to the action through actions of their own--and it was not desirable to deny them any release from their tensions. However, Shakespeare also knew that comedy and tragedy could be the two sides of the same coin--how often do we look back on some situations and

say, "I can laugh now, but not then?"

2) Modern audiences may consult programs for information regarding the progress of the play. Shakespeare's audiences enjoyed no such convenience. They were aware of rising action favoring the forces opposed to the protagonist and falling action introducing complications for the antagonist. To help his audiences appreciate what was happening, Shakespeare often employed the device used to start Act I, Scene 1, by reintroducing it after the climax in Act III. In *Macbeth* the audience first sees three witches waiting to encounter Macbeth; after the climax Macbeth himself seeks out the witches. In *Hamlet* the ghost imposes upon Hamlet the dreadful responsibility of revenge; after the climax the ghost again visits Hamlet to remind him of his solemn duty. *Othello* opens with Iago and Roderigo in the street scheming to alert Brabantio to Desdemona's elopement with the Moor; in Act IV, Scene 2, the two again are seen scheming the destruction of Cassio.

3) Shakespeare was unique in the importance he gave to women in his plays. Following the Act III climax, Shakespeare created a feeling of pathos through a female character who is innocent of wrongdoing yet is destroyed by the evil forces surrounding her. That evil destroys the innocent as well as the guilty is a recurring theme in Shakespeare's tragedies. In *Macbeth* Shakespeare had only one female character, Lady Macbeth, who had not hesitated to plan the murder of King Duncan so that her beloved Macbeth could fulfill his destiny--but was unable to carry it out herself. Despite her connivance at murder, Shakespeare daringly used Lady Macbeth to evoke pathos. After the Act III climax we see the once proud lady humbled by madness brought on by the rejection she has suffered at Macbeth's hands--he no longer needed her; he no longer confided in her, and her life had lost its purpose. In *Hamlet* Ophelia also goes mad after Hamlet murders her father--not intentionally, but the killing of her father by the man she loves causes the innocent Ophelia to take her own life. Desdemona in *Othello* is considered by some to be the most challenging of Shakespeare's female protagonists, for the audience must believe in her essential goodness. That she loves Othello even as he destroys her evokes powerful emotion, for she is an innocent victim of the evil that engulfs her.

4) Classic tragedy predicated that several deaths should occur at the end; Shakespeare never failed to meet this requirement. But he moved forward from the tragedy. Even as his audiences felt fear and pity as the drama ends, Shakespeare showed that the future is in good hands. In *Macbeth*, Scotland's future is safe in the hands of Macduff; in *Hamlet*, the future is left in the care of Fortinbras, so there will be no disquieting problem concerning Denmark's throne being rightfully occupied; in *Othello*, Cassio is restored to his place of honor in Othello's regard and will be responsible for the safe future of Cyprus.

Notes on the Play

- Language and Dialogue

1) Through the use of dialogue, the audience is informed of the setting, the time of day or night, the weather, and the identity of the characters.

2) Blank verse was the accepted form of writing for drama. When the protagonist lapsed into prose, the audience sensed a change in the character: he could be mad or he could be pretending to be someone else of a lower class.

3) In the play, Othello speaks in metaphors that attest to his greatness, courage, and nobility. Iago speaks in similes that constantly allude to animals and/or insects, and are heavy with innuendo.

4) Soliloquies generally indicate that a speaker is telling the truth. That sometimes has to be amended to the character's saying what he thinks to be the truth according to the interpretation he puts on rumor and hearsay. However, soliloquies do serve to characterize the speaker. They also forward the action as the speaker outlines his plan of action. In his soliloquies, Iago speaks well of Othello and we believe what he says as he is speaking for/to himself.

5) The songs used in the play were well known in Shakespeare's time. The songs serve a double purpose: Iago's in Act II:3 seem to be amusing but are used to tempt Cassio to drink and Desdemona's song in Act IV:3 evokes pity.

- Themes

- 1) Jealousy and Envy -- Jealousy and envy motivate Iago to plot the downfall of Othello.
 - Iago harbors a pathological jealousy where his wife is concerned: he is suspicious of every man with whom she comes in contact. He chooses to believe that both Othello and Cassio have trifled with her.
 - He also confesses to a jealous love of Desdemona. Iago's being able to describe the effects of jealousy as well as he does clearly shows his familiarity with the emotion.
 - Othello, too, is jealous--of his honor, of his reputation, of his nobility. He is of royal blood; he is legendary on the battlefield, and he is indispensable to Venice. When Iago suggests that Desdemona has committed adultery, Othello is primarily concerned with who he is and that his honor has been besmirched. Although he never ceases to love Desdemona, he believes she must die lest she betray someone else.
 - Envy differs from jealousy in that we envy those who can obtain something that we ourselves cannot obtain. Envy was considered to be an attribute of the devil himself. Iago envies Othello for winning the lovely Desdemona; he envies Cassio for his "daily beauty--that makes me ugly."

2) Appearance and Reality -- This was a favorite theme of Shakespeare's--what seems to be is not always what is.

- Everyone refers to Iago as "honest Iago"--his appearance suggests an honest man. He possesses an unerring instinct to know what to say to those he manipulates; he can be sympathetic, indignant, shocked--whatever the situation demands. Othello demands visible proof of Desdemona's infidelity--quite forgetting that what we see is not always what is. Iago stages scenes between Cassio and Desdemona and Bianca for Othello's benefit, making sure Othello only sees what is happening but cannot hear what is being said.

3) Witchcraft -- This is a minor theme but important to the overall action.

- Brabantio believes that Othello has bewitched Desdemona; she, in turn, believes the all-important handkerchief is bewitched because of Othello's description of how it has come to be and his insistence that Desdemona must produce it for him. Today we associate engagement rings with betrothals; in Shakespeare's time a handkerchief could be a betrothal gift. Handkerchiefs were expensive objects not usually found in the homes of the poor.

4) Light and Darkness -- This is a theme that grows in complexity as the action develops.

- In Act I, Scene 1, it basically involves the difference in skin color of Othello and Desdemona.
- As the tension grows, the concept of black and white assumes moral connotations--the blackness of evil is grasping for a noble soul.
- In the final scene Othello has become the black villain who has murdered purest innocence.

Othello is the only domestic tragedy that Shakespeare wrote. Domestic tragedies were generally believed to be of lesser significance than revenge or fall-of-princes tragedies, but in *Othello* Shakespeare proved that a domestic tragedy could also show the downfall of a noble protagonist and could evoke the classical emotions of pity and fear. The play in many respects, has more universal appeal than plays about royalty either gone mad or feigning madness. Othello, like Macbeth, falls victim to the snares of an evil that seems to offer something good. Othello describes himself as "one who loved not wisely, but too well"--surely a betrayal of such a love can evoke pity and fear. All of Shakespeare's tragic protagonists are flawed by pride; Othello becomes incensed when he thinks of Desdemona's demeaning him through adulterous behaviour. He is also flawed by a lack of self-knowledge; he believes he is not capable of jealousy and Iago capitalizes on this weakness.

Some critics have tried to suggest that Othello is too trusting, too gullible where Iago is concerned. However, Iago makes a practice of deceiving everybody--the Venetian Council, Cassio, Desdemona--all call him "honest Iago;" he delights in his power to deceive. Othello is also highly regarded by the Venetian Council, Cassio, Montano, Lodovico--and even Iago in the rare instances when he speaks the truth. When Iago perceives virtues in others he sneers at them as weaknesses and seeks to use them for his own ends. Othello, when he perceives others' virtues, strives to use them positively for the mutual benefit of the individuals concerned, of Othello himself, and of the Venetian state. There are very few people who have not experienced the disillusionment of discovering that what appears to be is not what really is.

-The Significance of Setting

Clever as Iago was in deceiving and manipulating people, he could not have succeeded as well as he did had the setting not been the island of Cyprus. Here Iago was able to control his cast Roderigo, Cassio, Emilia, Bianca, Desdemona, and Othello--he in effect, had them right where he wanted them.

The island setting also aided Iago in capitalizing on Othello's lack of knowledge of Venetian society. Othello was knowledgeable about war. He was an excellent general and commander of troops; however, his experience of the world off the battle field was limited. When Iago spoke

scathingly of the morals of wealthy Venetians, Othello had little choice but to believe him.

The island setting also enables Iago to deceive Montano and others of the Cypriot garrison concerning Cassio and Othello. Why should they doubt "honest" Iago?

Within the confines of Othello's residence on the island, Iago encounters no difficulties in "setting the scene" to provide the ocular evidence Othello demands to prove Desdemona is less than virtuous. The master dissembler obligingly provides the appearances that are not really what they seem.

-Bianca's Contribution to the Plot

That Bianca, the courtesan, should be on the island is to be expected, for courtesans did follow troop movements. That Bianca is enamoured of Cassio is also not surprising, for he is seen as a ladies' man charming Emilia and Desdemona. Cassio has no wife, so he is at liberty to avail himself of Bianca's charms. Iago needs another character in the little drama that he is busily arranging and Bianca fills the role perfectly.

Elizabethan Beliefs

An important aspect of Shakespeare's writings is the use he makes of the universally held beliefs in a system of world order. In Renaissance times allusions to these beliefs are found in writings of all the nations of the Western world. The beliefs began with the assumption that before creation, Chaos ruled the universe. With creation, God imposed a system of order throughout the universe. The order consisted of a series of parallels of ascending order in all aspects of creation: heaven, earth, planets, animals, fish, birds, plants, insects, and man himself.

God	Earth
Cherubim/Seraphim	
Archangels	King/Emperor
Angels	
MAN	the nobility
Planets	
Animals	the governing body
Fish	
Birds	the body politic
Plants	
Insects	
(Man is at the center as man is earthy and divine.)	(Each of these also has an ascending order.)

Within each step in the ladder of creation a similar order is found, also rising from the least

to the most important. The sun headed the planets; the lion the animals; the dolphin the fish; the eagle the birds; the rose the flowers; the oak the trees; and the bee the insects. Also included in the belief in order was the view that Heaven and the Celestial Bodies were in sympathy with the human world. This sympathy is shown in many of Shakespeare's plays. In *Julius Caesar* graves opened, the dead walked, and a lion whelped in the Forum the night preceding Caesar's assassination. When Duncan was murdered in *Macbeth* a violent storm occurred and the King's own horses ate each other. Othello's allusion to Chaos in lines 101-102 in Act III:3, "And when I love thee not/Chaos is come again" would send a thrill of horror through Shakespeare's audience at the immensity of the evil that is threatening Othello's very soul.

The Temptation Scene - Act III:3

The temptation scene, as it has been named, is the high point of the drama. Iago is supremely triumphant as he brings the noble Othello to his knees in a cynical parody of prayer. This is the very "Divinity of Hell" (Act II:3:370) that Iago delights in. Othello's words as he rises from his knees, "I greet thy love" (line 533) underline the malevolence of Iago and the trust of Othello. For the while Iago is content that Cassio has been marked for death and that he, Iago, is now lieutenant. There is more yet for him to devise as is implied in his suggestive, "But let her live" (line 540).

The Falling Action

The reaching of the climax in no way lessens the suspense. Iago has achieved some significant success, but there are complications to be dealt with:

- Othello's continuing love for Desdemona
- arranging for the visible proof Othello demands
- the arrival of the Venetian delegation
- Roderigo's threat to go to Desdemona regarding the jewels.

In *Othello* Shakespeare presents a monumental struggle between implacable evil and magnanimous integrity. Iago is the culmination of Shakespeare's examination of human evil, starting with Richard III, proceeding to Macbeth, and achieving the epitome of evil in Iago. Ironically, Othello's great-souled integrity is no match for the evil that reduces his nobility, faith, and honor to barbaric mindless fury. Othello expresses the essence of the struggle best: "Of one, not easily jealous but being wrought/Perplexed in the extreme . . . threw a pearl away" (Act V:2:405-407).

Suggested Writing Topics

1. Does good or evil triumph in *Othello*?
2. Analyze and assess the different types of love in *Othello*.

3. Is Othello a tragic hero? Why or why not?
4. Discuss Shakespeare's view and presentation of women in the play.
5. Analyze the character of Iago.
6. Discuss the strengths and weaknesses of the relationship between Othello and Desdemona.
7. Analyze Emilia's contribution to the play.
8. Discuss in detail the impression of Othello as he is presented in the first two acts of the play.
9. Explain the importance and contribution of two of the following characters: Cassio, Roderigo, or Bianca.
10. Why is Iago so effective as a villain?
11. Analyze and discuss the purpose of the animal imagery used throughout the play.
12. Analyze the use of setting (Venice and Cyprus in particular) in the play.

Viewing

- View the 1995 film version of *Othello* starring Laurence Fishburne and Irene Jacob. The movie was directed by Kenneth Branagh (124 minutes).

Act I - 0 - 21 min
 Act II - 21 - 46 min
 Act III - 46 - 1.07 min
 Act IV - 1.07 - 1.33
 Act V - 1.33 - 1.59